

Request for Information

This Request for Information (RFI) represents one of several steps taken to provide the Army and Air Force Exchange Service (the Exchange) with an understanding of the capabilities and potential providers to license the right to operate, process, bottle, distribute, and sell drinking water.

In the second phase of the project, the survey marketplace will be screened, and the result will establish a list of potential licensors that appear to be interested in entering into a license and distribution agreement with the Exchange for services to specific locations. The contents of this RFI document are as follows:

- I.** Organizational Profile
- II.** Introduction
- III.** General Offeror Information
- IV.** RFI Facility/Demographic Information (For Assistance in Determining Interest)

I. Organizational Profile:

The Army and Air Force Exchange Service (the Exchange) is a federal instrumentality that is a unique organization within the Department of Defense. The Exchange utilizes non-appropriated funds and sales revenue to offset operating costs. The Exchange returns its earnings to its customers through improved facilities and payments to Morale, Welfare and Recreation (MWR) programs.

The Army & Air Force Exchange Service is the 53rd largest retail organization in the U.S., with annual revenue of \$7.53B and employing 35,000 civilian and military personnel. The Exchange operates retail and convenience stores, gas stations, restaurants, theaters, vending and other businesses on military installations in all 50 states, five U.S. territories and more than 30 countries. The Exchange is responsible for more than 4,900 facilities worldwide, operating 122 main stores, 167 Military Clothing facilities, 685 Specialty Stores (Troops Stores, Service Stations, Express Stores, Class Six outlets, bookstores, etc.) and 72 theaters. 1,626 food facilities (815 Direct and 637 Concession); the Exchange is a licensed franchisee to over 20 food brands and over 25 name brand concession.

The Exchange has four (4) bakeries overseas (three are located in the Pacific Region and one in Germany). Our two (2) water plants are located in Vicenza, Italy and Grunstadt, Germany as well as an ice plant. The Exchange is an IBWA member; we have three (3) Certified Plant Operators (CPO); our own certified Quality Assurance Lab on site where U.S. military members are trained.

Our water meets the following regulations and guidelines:

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- NSF (National Sanitation Foundation)
- FDA (U.S. Food & Drug Administration) Title 21, Code of Federal Regulation
- GMPs (Good Manufacturing Practices)

The Exchange has a two-fold mission that has remained essentially unchanged since the military exchange system was established in July 1895:

- To provide quality merchandise and services at uniformly low prices to soldiers, airmen and their families wherever they are stationed around the world.
- To generate reasonable earnings to support Army and Air Force Morale, Welfare and Recreation (MWR) programs.

For further information about our company, please refer to the Exchange website (www.shopmyexchange.com).

II. Introduction

Purpose:

The Exchange is currently soliciting information from companies that can provide license the right to operate, process, bottle, distribute, and sell drinking water in our overseas patrons.

The information solicited will focus on your desire to provide a license for the Exchange to provide the services to captured customers within the Army and Air Force Bases Outside Continental United States (OCONUS), specifically in Europe and SW Asia. The Exchange is looking to expand its current source list of providers within this industry.

Please note the following timeline for this engagement:

Issue RFI	<u>11 Apr 2025</u>
Last date to submit written questions	<u>25 Apr 2025 @ 12:00PM CST</u>
Responses Due	<u>15 May 2025 @ 2:00PM CST</u>

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Respondents are provided an opportunity to ask questions. Questions must be submitted in writing and will be accepted by e-mail to shillingfordt@aafes.com on or before **25 Apr 2025**. Answers to all questions received will be sent out via a follow-up message to all parties on the initial RFI submission.

Responses to the RFI questions and completed chart will be accepted by e-mail to shillingfordt@aafes.com on or before **15 May 2025**.

Conditions

Several Potential Offerors will be solicited to respond to this RFI.

The receipt of a response to this RFI from a potential offeror does not imply any contractual obligation on the part of the Exchange nor does it create any further obligation on the part of the Exchange.

The Exchange considers this RFI and all correspondence, electronic, oral or written communications, documentation, business dealings, or related activity in connection with the RFI to be confidential in nature. The Exchange does not wish its activity with regard to this RFI to be available to anyone other than the potential offerors' own personnel (on a "need to know" basis). Therefore, the potential offeror may not disclose to anyone other than (i) Exchange personnel directly involved with this RFI and (ii) the personnel authorized and assigned by the potential offeror to act on behalf of the potential offeror in connection with this RFI. All materials contained within your response to this RFI will be treated confidentially. This information will, however, be made available to all project team members to assist in the evaluation process.

Responses to this RFI will be considered as informational in nature and only an executed contract between the parties will create any obligations on behalf of the Exchange. All written and oral information presented during the procurement process and all responses to this RFI may be made part of any final agreement or contract between the Exchange and the selected firm(s). Responses must be signed by an individual authorized to make contractual commitments for the Potential Offeror.

In keeping with Exchange policy, issuance of this RFI does not commit the Exchange (i) to pay any costs incurred by a Potential Offeror in the preparation and submission of a response or (ii) to procure a contract for any services.

Potential Offeror Response Requirements

In order to control the RFI process and allow equal opportunity for each potential offeror, the following guidelines must be followed without exception.

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All responses must be in written and electronic (MS Word) .docx format. Note: A copy of this document will be provided in “form” format for your fill-in convenience. Responses can be entered and saved.

We will rely upon all representations made by your representatives, whether verbal or written, during the acquisition and evaluation processes. As a result, only fact-based and realistic commitments/information should be conveyed. Your representations and expertise in this type of transaction will be documented in any agreement that results from the acquisition process.

III. General Potential Offeror Information

1. What is your Company’s official name?

Vendor Response:

2. Is your Company involved in any litigation, investigation, reorganization, receivership, filing, strike, audit, corporate acquisition or any other action that could have an adverse impact on your ability to provide services? If so, please describe the nature of the item and its potential impact.
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Vendor Response:

3. Does your company have any active contracts with the US Government or any federal entity?

Vendor Response:

4. When was your company established?
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Vendor Response:

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5. The Exchange prefers to start/maintain lasting business partnerships with providers for terms of 10 years at a minimum. Can your company comply? What is the standard length of a license agreement?

Vendor Response:

6. Which Brand(s) of water does your company offer?

Vendor Response:

7. What size(s) of bottled water does your company offer? Is there any flexibility to the sizes?

Vendor Response:

8. Please provide any minimum or necessary requirements that a potential Licensee would need to meet to become an authorized operator and distributor.

Vendor Response:

9. Is there a minimum volume? If yes, please provide details and frequency (i.e. monthly, quarterly, annually)?

Vendor Response:

10. What are the standard license fees to operate? Please list all categories and fees to operate? Are marketing monies available to Licensees?

Vendor Response:

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Point of Contact (POC)

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| <p>11. If your company is interested in being included in any resultant Request for Proposal (RFP), please provide pertinent contact information such as name, address, telephone and email information of the person that the RFP should be sent to.</p> |
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Vendor Response:

If you are not interested at this time, please respond via email with your request to decline participation in future efforts for any and all Exchange locations.

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IV. RFI Facility & Volume Information

The following information is provided as part of the RFI for informational purposes only as a way for invited firms to gauge the current business. The below numbers and information is based on the FY24 numbers.

WATER PLANT FACILITIES

Region	Facility	Historical Volume	12 mth Total Historical Sales	Approx. Square Footage	Future Month Volume	Home Delivery Sales	Current Bottle Sizes
EUR	Germany	3.91M Gallons	\$4.6M	93,000 sqf	325,833 Gallons	\$2.3M	0.25 ltr 0.5 ltr 1.0 ltr 1.5 ltr 5 Gal
EUR	Italy	239K Gallons	\$160K	4,000 sqm	19,970 Gallons	\$319K	5 Gal

Firms responding to this notice are advised that their response to this notice is not a request that will be considered for contract award. All interested parties will be required to respond to the solicitation separately from their response to this notice.